lived. Nevertheless, Jewish people kept alive their religious traditions, building **synagogues** for worship and celebrating Jewish festivals and holy days.

Anti-Semitism in Europe

The Jews were often persecuted. Almost all Europeans were Christians and they often forced the Jews to live in separate areas. The Jews were not allowed to vote or even to buy their own land. Then, when **persecution** increased in the Middle Ages, the Jews were expelled from much of western Europe and many settled in Russia and Poland.

In the nineteenth century, the country with the largest Jewish population was Russia. When the Tsar (emperor) was assassinated in 1881, there were a lot of anti-Jewish riots. Many people in the government blamed the Jews for the assassination and the new Tsar's government encouraged the persecution of the Jews. Synagogues were burnt down, Jewish homes were attacked and thousands of Jews were killed. Many Russian Jews fled to western Europe and the USA. But, even there, Jews often found that they were not treated as equals and that they were sometimes suspected of being disloyal or untrustworthy. All these various forms of anti-Jewish behaviour are known as **anti-Semitism**.

In 1896, Theodor Herzl, an Austrian Jew living in Paris, published a book entitled *The Jewish State*. In it, he wrote:

> Are we to get out now, and where to? Or may we remain, and how long? Let us first settle the point of staying where we are now. Can we hope for better days? I say we cannot hope for change in the current feeling. Even if we were as near the hearts of princes as are their other subjects, they could not protect us. They would only feed popular hatred by showing us too much favour.

He said his plan was 'perfectly simple': the Jews were to be granted 'a portion of the globe large enough to satisfy the rightful requirements of a nation'.

> We must not imagine the departure of the Jews to be a sudden one. It will be gradual, continuous and will cover many decades. The poorest will go first to cultivate the soil.
>
> They will construct roads, bridges, railways and telegraph installations, regulate rivers and build their own dwellings; their labour will create trade, trade will create markets and markets will attract new settlers.

'Next year in Jerusalem'

For hundreds of years Jews dreamt and prayed that they would be able to celebrate 'Next Year in Jerusalem'. By the beginning of the twentieth century, an increasing number of Jews in Europe and the USA were, like Herzl, demanding a Jewish national home. By 1914, when the First World War broke out, these people were all agreed that this homeland would have to be in Palestine. This was the **'Promised Land'**, where the Jews (or **Israelites**) had

Key terms

Synagogue
A building where Jews worship.

Persecution
Punishment or cruel treatment, often because of ethnicity or religion.

Anti-Semitism
Feelings or actions showing prejudice or hatred towards the Jews.

'Promised Land'
The land of Palestine (which Jews believed God had promised to them).

Israelites
The name by which Jews were known in ancient times, hence the 'Land of Israel' was their Promised Land.